Key term

**Palestinian Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP)** An organisation set up by George Habash, a Palestinian Christian. It carried out many terrorist acts.

activities of the various groups within the PLO. Like most of the PLO leaders, he wanted to limit the raids and the bombings to Israeli territory and Israeli targets because their military aim was strictly war on Israel. However, some more radical Palestinian groups, such as the **Palestinian Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP)**, started to carry out attacks in other parts of the world. They pointed out that raids into Israel had achieved very little. They were impatient. They were not prepared to wait 10 or 20 years to regain their country. Some of their views are shown on page 82.

Key question
What terrorist attacks were carried out?

## Hijacks and hostages

In December 1968 two Palestinians, members of the PFLP, hijacked an Israeli passenger plane at Athens airport in Greece, killing one man. The Israelis retaliated by destroying 13 aircraft in an attack on Beirut airport in Lebanon, which is where the hijackers had come from. In the following years there were many hijackings, kidnappings and bombings in Europe and elsewhere. At first the targets were Israeli planes, embassies and offices but, in February 1970, a Swiss plane was blown up on its way to Israel. The Israelis usually responded to these attacks by bombing Palestinian bases in Lebanon, Jordan and Syria. Often these bases were near refugee camps so that hundreds of innocent Palestinians died. These Israeli reprisals received far less publicity in the Western press than the Palestinian attacks.

Key question
Why was the PLO expelled from Jordan?

Key date

PLO expelled from Jordan: 1970

## The PLO are expelled from Jordan 1970

Sometimes terrorist violence led Arab to fight Arab. In Jordan, King Hussein feared the Israeli reprisals which followed Palestinian attacks that were launched from his country. In 1968 his troops had helped the Palestinians to inflict heavy casualties on the Israelis at Karameh. However, in September 1970, he decided he did not want any more raids launched on Israel from inside Jordan. Besides, members of the PLO were acting as if they ruled much of Jordan, not just the refugee camps: they were roaming round fully armed and setting up road blocks, even in Amman, the Jordanian capital. So he ordered the Palestinians to obey him and his army.

Then, in the same month, four aircraft were hijacked by the PFLP and three of the planes (belonging to British, Swiss and American airlines) were taken to a Palestinian base in Jordan. The hijackers demanded the release of Palestinian fighters held in British, German and Swiss, as well as Israeli, jails. The passengers were set free but the British plane was blown up. This incident was the last straw for King Hussein. It was a direct challenge to his authority and he feared foreign intervention. He was forced to act. He ordered his army to take control of the PLO bases. The Palestinians resisted and, in the next 10 days, more than 3000 of them were killed. The PLO offices in Jordan were shut down and their newspapers banned. The remaining fighters went to Syria and Lebanon.